CASTE SYSTEM: STRUCTURE AND CONTEMPORARY DYNAMICS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS → FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR → MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE → MOBILITY STRATEGIES → DOMINANT CASTE TEST → CASTE AND CLASS

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g1 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 LEVEL OF ANALYSIS

LEVEL OF ANALYSIS | FOUR-FOLD TEXTUAL IDEAL TYPE, NORMATIVE | LOCAL ENDOGAMOUS BIRTH GROUP, OBSERVABLE | NARROWER ENDOGAMY CIRCLE INSIDE A JATI | ANSWER AT THE JATI LEVEL, ARGUE WITH THE VARNA

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative	SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati	VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative
JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable	RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template	JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative
- JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- SUB-JATI → narrower endogamy circle inside a jati
- RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- VARNA → four-fold textual ideal type, normative
- JATI → local endogamous birth group, observable

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → answer at the jati level, argue with the varna template.

01

STAGE 01 FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE

FOUR FEATURES AND THEIR RATE OF CHANGE | MOST CONSISTENTLY OBSERVED, CHANGES LEAST | LOCALLY RANKED BY PURITY AND POLLUTION | HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP | FIXED BY BIRTH | OCCUPATION LINK | WEAKEST JOINT, BROKEN BY URBAN WORK

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
ENDOGAMY → most consistently observed, changes least	HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth	ENDOGAMY → most consistently observed, changes least
HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution	OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work	HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- ENDOGAMY → most consistently observed, changes least
- HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP → fixed by birth
- OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- ENDOGAMY → most consistently observed, changes least
- HIERARCHY → locally ranked by purity and pollution

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: OCCUPATION LINK → weakest joint, broken by urban work.

02

STAGE 02 MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER

MARRIAGE RULES THAT OPERATE TOGETHER | CASTE ENDOGAMY | MARRY WITHIN THE JATI | GOTRA EXOGAMY | MARRY OUTSIDE THE CLAN LINEAGE | A BOUNDED BUT NON-CONSANGUINEOUS MARRIAGE CIRCLE | CASTE IS REPRODUCED GENERATION BY GENERATION

CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati → GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage → RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle → CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle
- CONSEQUENCE → caste is reproduced generation by generation

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- CASTE ENDOGAMY → marry within the jati
- GOTRA EXOGAMY → marry outside the clan lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RESULT → a bounded but non-consanguineous marriage circle.

03

STAGE 03 MOBILITY STRATEGIES

MOBILITY STRATEGIES | EMULATE A LOCALLY HIGHER-STATUS CASTE | CLAIMS RANK INSIDE THE EXISTING HIERARCHY | NEW VALUES FROM WESTERN CONTACT | CAN SUBVERT THE HIERARCHY RATHER THAN CONFIRM IT

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste	WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact	SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy	EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it	EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- WESTERNISATION → new values from Western contact
- EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- SANSKRITISATION → emulate a locally higher-status caste
- EFFECT → claims rank inside the existing hierarchy

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EFFECT → can subvert the hierarchy rather than confirm it.

04

STAGE 04 DOMINANT CASTE TEST

DOMINANT CASTE TEST | IS THE CASTE LOCALLY NUMEROUS | DOES IT HOLD A SIGNIFICANT SHARE OF LOCAL LAND | DOES IT CONTROL POLITICAL AND PANCHAYAT POSITIONS | DOMINANCE CAN SIT BELOW THE RITUAL TOP

NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous

LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land → OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions → VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous
- LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- OFFICE → does it control political and Panchayat positions
- VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- NUMBERS → is the caste locally numerous
- LAND → does it hold a significant share of local land

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → dominance can sit below the ritual top.

05

STAGE 05 CASTE AND CLASS

CASTE AND CLASS | CASTE RANK AND ECONOMIC CLASS COINCIDE LOCALLY | RICH AND POOR HOUSEHOLDS INSIDE ONE CASTE | URBAN EMPLOYMENT AND MARKET CREDENTIALS | THE OVERLAP IS LOOSENING, NOT ABOLISHED

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally	DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials	OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste	LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished	CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- DRIVER → urban employment and market credentials
- LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- OVERLAP → caste rank and economic class coincide locally
- CROSS-CUTTING → rich and poor households inside one caste

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → the overlap is loosening, not abolished.

06

STAGE 06 ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION

ASSOCIATIONAL REINVENTION | OCCUPATIONAL ALLOCATION AND PUBLIC PURITY ENFORCEMENT | REPLACED BY | CASTE ASSOCIATIONS, TRUSTS AND ELECTORAL BLOCS | ENDOGAMY AND INTIMATE-SPHERE DISCRIMINATION | CHANGE OF REGISTER, NOT DISAPPEARANCE

WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement → REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs → UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination → VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement
- REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- UNCHANGED → endogamy and intimate-sphere discrimination
- VERDICT → change of register, not disappearance

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- WEAKENED → occupational allocation and public purity enforcement
- REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: REPLACED BY → caste associations, trusts and electoral blocs.

07

STAGE 07 FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL

FLUID AND STATIC RESOLVED BY LEVEL | STATIC LAYER | ENDOGAMY, HEREDITARY MEMBERSHIP, SEGREGATION | FLUID LAYER | RANK CLAIMS, DOMINANCE, MARKET MOBILITY | RANK IS LOCALLY CONSTRUCTED, BOUNDARY IS MARITAL | THE PARADOX IS A LEVEL DISTINCTION, NOT A CONTRADICTION

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation
- FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- WHY → rank is locally constructed, boundary is marital
- ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- STATIC LAYER → endogamy, hereditary membership, segregation
- FLUID LAYER → rank claims, dominance, market mobility

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER → the paradox is a level distinction, not a contradiction.

08

STAGE 08 IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA

IDENTITY AXES BY ARENA | JATI AND SUB-JATI DECIDE THE BOUNDARY | SHRINE AND DEVOTION | SECT THROUGH DOCTRINE AND LINEAGE | ELECTORAL MOBILISATION | JATI CLUSTERS AND RELIGION | DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE | REGION AND LANGUAGE

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary	ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion	MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage	DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language	SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
- SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- ELECTORAL MOBILISATION → jati clusters and religion
- DEVELOPMENT GRIEVANCE → region and language

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- MARRIAGE → jati and sub-jati decide the boundary
- SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SHRINE AND DEVOTION → sect through doctrine and lineage.

09

STAGE 09 TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES

TWO MARRIAGE BOUNDARIES | PARITY PROTECTS STATUS AND RESOURCE BASE | BELONGING, KINSHIP AND COMMUNITY SANCTION | CIVIL ROUTE | SPECIAL MARRIAGE ACT, 1954 EXISTS ACROSS RELIGIONS | DIFFERENT GUARDS, THEREFORE DIFFERENT SPEEDS

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base	CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions	INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction	VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds	INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
- INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions
- VERDICT → different guards, therefore different speeds

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- INTERCASTE → parity protects status and resource base
- INTERRELIGIOUS → belonging, kinship and community sanction

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CIVIL ROUTE → Special Marriage Act, 1954 exists across religions.

10

STAGE 10 MEASUREMENT STATUS

MEASUREMENT STATUS | PIB 30 APRIL 2025 | CASTE ENUMERATION ANNOUNCED FOR CENSUS 2027 | GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) | FIXES THE REFERENCE DATES | PROSPECTIVE, SO NO CASTE COUNT MAY BE QUOTED | NOT INDIA'S FIRST HISTORICAL CASTE ENUMERATION

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027	STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted	PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027
GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates	LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration	GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027
- GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- STATUS → prospective, so no caste count may be quoted
- LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- PIB 30 APRIL 2025 → caste enumeration announced for Census 2027
- GAZETTE S.O. 2681(E) → fixes the reference dates

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LIMIT → not India's first historical caste enumeration.

11

STAGE 11 CASTE ANSWER SPINE

CASTE ANSWER SPINE | NAME THE LEVEL AND THE DEMAND FAMILY | STRUCTURE, MOBILITY, DOMINANCE, ASSOCIATION | WHAT CHANGED AGAINST WHAT DID NOT | ARENA-SPECIFIC VERDICT WITH THE MEASUREMENT CAVEAT

OPEN → name the level and the demand family → BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association → TENSION → what changed against what did not → CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- OPEN → name the level and the demand family
- BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- TENSION → what changed against what did not
- CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- OPEN → name the level and the demand family
- BODY → structure, mobility, dominance, association

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → arena-specific verdict with the measurement caveat.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT | CASTE ASSOCIATIONS AS POLITICAL INTERMEDIARIES | JATI-LEVEL BODIES INCREASINGLY | CASTE-CENSUS DEBATE (SOCIOLOGICAL, NOT ENUMERATION-METHODOLOGY) | DEMANDS FOR | RESERVATION AS A STRUCTURAL RESPONSE (CROSS-LINKED, NOT RESTATED) | URBAN CASTE PERSISTENCE | EVEN WHERE RITUAL PRACTICES WEAKEN, CASTE-BASED NETWORKS

OPTIONAL THEORETICAL DEPTH
- CAUTION: Caste associations as political intermediaries: jati-level bodies increasingly
- CAUTION: Caste-census debate (sociological, not enumeration-methodology): demands for
- Reservation as a structural response (cross-linked, not restated); constitutional
- CAUTION: Urban caste persistence: even where ritual practices weaken, caste-based networks

DATA / CLAIM LIMIT
- CAUTION: Boundary case 1: a Sanskritising jati that gains ritual respectability but remains
- CAUTION: Boundary case 2: a numerically dominant but ritually middling caste controlling a
- CAUTION: Boundary case 3: an intercaste marriage between two economically equal
- CAUTION: Sanskritisation's ceiling: emulation can raise local ritual standing but cannot by

COMPARATIVE SOCIAL NUANCE
- CAUTION: Marriage-trend generalisation risk: the 2024 PYQ's trend (rising intercaste,
- M.N. Srinivas developed both Sanskritisation and dominant caste from his Rampura
- Dominant caste is defined by numbers + land + political power, independent of ritual
- Sanskritisation operates within the existing hierarchy; Westernisation introduces

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels